



AN OLYMPIAN DILEMMA

The Government's policy of putting the lid on Tibetan protests has the BJP charging it with going soft on China. But an aggressive anti-China posture may prove counterproductive in the long run.

■ By Raj Chengappa

Midnight knocks are associated with jackboot dictatorships and in India with the Emergency. But suprisingly in China these are considered routine especially for diplomats stationed in Beijing. The Chinese Foreign Ministry thinks nothing of summoning envoys in the middle of the night pointing out that Chairman Mao Tse Tung's famous meeting with US President Richard Nixon in 1972 took place at 3 a.m.

So it seems that when Nirupama Rao, India's ambassador to China, received a call a little after midnight of March 22 informing her that she had been summoned by the Chinese Foreign Ministry, she wasn't perturbed. She was awake reading and in an hour she was on her way to the Foreign Ministry.

There Rao was ushered in to meet Wu Dawei, the Chinese vice-foreign minister, who apologised for the late hour and then expressed concern over reports that Tibetans were making an attempt to cross the border from India into China through the Nathu La Pass. He wanted an assurance that India would tighten its border security and prevent any inflammatory incidents.

Significantly, Wu didn't mention the intrusion of Tibetan protesters in the Chinese Embassy in Delhi the previous evening. But next morning the news of the summons was out and the outrage in the media apparent. The Indian Foreign Ministry had a hard time explaining that Rao had not been singled out for a midnight demarche. More so because it came at the climax of week-long protests by Tibetans over the crack-down in Lhasa that threatened to get out

of hand. A few days earlier US Congress Speaker Nancy Pelosi, on a visit to Delhi, had flown to Dharamsala and holding the Dalai Lama's hand called the recent events in Tibet as "a challenge to the conscience of the world".

Suddenly India's relations with China, that had seen a sharp upswing over the years, seemed in danger of experiencing a setback. It didn't help that a sensitive foreign issue with India's largest and most powerful neighbour was embroiled in domestic politics. The usually vociferous Left parties were silent over the Tibetan crisis exposing where their sympathies lay, but BJP went ballistic. In a joint statement, BJP senior leaders L.K. Advani, Rajnath Singh and Jaswant Singh, said: "It is indeed shameful to note that the Government of India, instead of expressing concern over the use of force